Lesson 19: Grammar: Adjective Clauses

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 2: Sentences and Paragraph Types · American History

Adapted from High-Intermediate Academic Grammar for ESL Students by Rebecca Al Haider, Reedley College (CC BY 4.0): 5.5: Grammar Presentation-Adjective Clauses; 5.6: Applying Grammar to Reading; 5.7: Communication Practice.

In this lesson

You will learn to combine two sentences into one with an adjective clause (who, whom, which, that, whose, where, when), to punctuate restrictive and non-restrictive clauses, and to shorten clauses into phrases. You will also learn three common errors. Academic texts like "Life on Reservations" use adjective clauses to give exact information about a noun, so this grammar helps you read them and write more precise sentences.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Choose the right relative pronoun for people, things, places, times and possession.
- Decide if a clause is restrictive (no commas) or non-restrictive (commas).
- Combine two sentences with a relative pronoun, and choose who or whom.
- Reduce an adjective clause to a phrase.
- Avoid errors with verb agreement, repeated pronouns and clause placement.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
clause; dependent clause	a group of words with a subject and a verb; a dependent clause cannot stand alone as a sentence	who is absent today
adjective clause	a dependent clause that describes a noun	The girl who is sitting in the front is new.
relative pronoun	the word that begins an adjective clause and replaces a noun	The person who stole my car left it parked on Mainstreet.
antecedent	the noun that the adjective clause describes	The cars that are in the street need to be moved. (cars)
restrictive clause	a clause with information you need to identify the noun; no commas	The car that is in my driveway is my brother's.
non-restrictive clause	a clause with extra information about a noun that is already clear; commas	My car, which needs to be washed, rides smoothly.
phrase	a group of words without both a subject and a verb	sitting in the front

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
appositive	a noun phrase that renames the noun before it	The author, Dr. Bettina L. Love, is …

Rules and explanations

Relative pronouns

Pronoun	Refers to	Function in the clause
which	specific things (not people); used with commas	subject, object, or object of a preposition
that	general things or people; not used with commas	subject or object
who	people	subject
whom	people	object or object of a preposition
whose	possession (replaces his, her, its, their)	subject or object
when	time	object
where	place	object

Restrictive or non-restrictive?

- **Restrictive** (no commas): the clause tells the reader **which** noun. The girl who is sitting in the front is new. The car that is in my driveway is my brother's.
- **Non-restrictive** (commas): the reader already knows the noun, for example from a name or "my". Mariam, who is absent today, speaks K'iche. My car, which needs to be washed, rides smoothly.

Combining two sentences: three steps

1. Move the second sentence next to the noun it describes.
2. Replace the repeated noun or pronoun with a relative pronoun, and put the relative pronoun at the start of the clause.
3. Punctuate: commas for a non-restrictive clause, no commas for a restrictive clause.

Type	Two sentences	Combined
subject	The person left my car parked on Mainstreet. The person stole my car.	The person who stole my car left it parked on Mainstreet.
object	The woman likes square dancing. You met the woman at the party.	The woman whom you met at the party likes square dancing.
whose	The teacher explains topics very well. I am taking her class.	The teacher whose class I am taking explains topics very well.
where	The room has been updated. My class is in that room.	The room where my class is has been updated.

- With whose, move whose + its noun to the start of the clause (whose class).
- With where and when, delete the words for the place or time (in that room, on that day): I remember the day when I first met you.

Who or whom?

- A **subject** relative pronoun is the subject of the clause, so a **verb** follows it: The woman who **drove** me home last night works for a taxi company.
- An **object** relative pronoun is the object of the clause, so a **noun or pronoun + verb** follows it: The woman whom **you met** at the party Friday likes square dancing.

Reducing adjective clauses to phrases

- **who / which / that + be:** delete the relative pronoun and be. The girl who is sitting in the front is new. → The girl sitting in the front is new. The author, who is Dr. Bettina L. Love, … → The author, Dr. Bettina L. Love, … (an appositive)
- Exception: if only an adjective follows be, do not reduce. "The fruit, which is fresh, …" cannot become "The fruit fresh"; write "The fresh fruit".
- **who / which / that + another verb:** delete the relative pronoun and change the verb to -ing. Anyone who wants to participate → Anyone wanting to participate should contact a counselor.

Common errors

- **Agreement:** the verb in the clause agrees with the antecedent. The car that **is** in the driveway **needs** a new tire. The cars that **are** in the street **need** to be moved.
- **Repeating the subject or object:** the relative pronoun replaces it. Not: The man who he drove us home … / The book that I bought it online arrives tomorrow.
- **Placement:** put the clause next to its noun. Not: The restaurant served a plate to the woman that was dirty. (The woman was dirty?) Correct: The restaurant served a plate that was dirty to the woman.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic relative clauses keep a pronoun for the noun ("the book that I read it"). In English the relative pronoun replaces it: The book that I read. - Arabic uses no relative pronoun after an indefinite noun, so learners may write "I have a friend lives in Chicago". In English a subject relative pronoun is needed: I have a friend who lives in Chicago.

Practice

Exercise 12: Restrictive and non-restrictive clauses. Find the adjective clause. Is it a) Restrictive or b) Non-Restrictive?

1. The United States, which has the highest incarceration rate in the world, is experiencing a crisis.
2. The country whose economy is collapsing has not responded to its citizens' needs.
3. The radio station that plays soft rock has poor reception near the freeway.
4. My favorite radio station, which often plays Stevie Nicks, has a great signal at my house.

5. The woman who smokes in her car works for an office that prohibits smoking on its property.

Exercise 15: Who or whom? Choose a) who or b) whom. Who is followed by a verb; whom is followed by a subject (noun or pronoun).

1. The man _____ drove us home last night works for a ride-share company.
2. The man _____ Vicki loves is married to another woman.
3. The singer _____ sings the #1 hit on the billboard chart has sold over 2 million copies.
4. The singer _____ we saw in concert in Las Vegas has sold out every concert this year.
5. The student _____ sits next to me chews gum loudly.
6. The student _____ the teacher called on was not prepared to answer.
7. The author _____ our school invited to speak has an inspirational story.
8. The author _____ immigrated to the US as a child is a professor at Santa Clara University.
9. The player _____ has the most scores this season injured her leg in the last game.
10. The athlete _____ I admire the most did not compete in the Olympics.

Exercise 17: Where and when. Combine the sentences. Use the second sentence as the adjective clause, with where or when.

1. The place is outdoor. I got married there.
2. The building collapsed. Irene lived there.
3. The library closes at 3PM on Fridays. I spend most of my time at the library.
4. The house has changed a lot. I grew up in that house.
5. The day was the best day of my life. You were born on that day.
6. I was sick Tuesday. I had an exam on Tuesday.
7. February is the month. The temperatures are usually the coldest in that month.

Exercise 18: Reducing adjective clauses. Choose the best phrase to replace the adjective clause.

1. The students who want to meet with a tutor should put their names here. a) want to meet with a tutor b) wanted to meet with a tutor c) wanting to meet with a tutor d) no reduction possible
2. The books that were placed on the back table have disappeared. a) being placed on the back table b) were placed on the back table c) placed on the back table d) no reduction possible
3. The cities that are located east of the river have access to more water. a) that located east of the river b) being located east of the river c) located east of the river d) no reduction possible
4. Spiderman, who has great strength and responsibility, tracks down Cindy Moon. a) having great strength and responsibility b) had great strength and responsibility c) no reduction possible
5. Spiderman is a superhero who was created by Stan Lee. a) being created by Stan Lee b) created by Stan Lee c) no reduction possible
6. Captain America, who is a Marvel superhero, first appeared in 1941. a) being a Marvel superhero b) a Marvel superhero c) no reduction possible

Exercise 19: Choosing the right verb. Choose the verb that agrees with the antecedent.

1. The Pacific Ocean is the world's largest ocean that _____ from the Artic in the north to the Southern Ocean in the south. a) extend b) extends c) extended
2. Michael Phelps, who _____ a champion swimmer, won eight gold medals in the 2008 Olympics. a) is b) are c) being
3. Cacao, which _____ sold to chocolate-processing companies, _____ harvested by hand. a) is, was b) is, were c) is, is d) was, were
4. Sarah wants to buy the sofas that _____ in the window display of the department store. a) is b) are c) was
5. The tools that _____ stolen _____ to be replaced. a) is, needs b) are, need c) was, needs d) were, need
6. The people who _____ late _____ marked absent. a) was, was b) was, were c) were, were

Exercise 20: Repeated subjects or objects, and placement. Copy the sentences and correct them.

1. The book that I bought it through Amazon arrived late.
2. I went to the shopping mall with my friend that is the biggest in America.
3. The rooms where they go to them will be prepared.
4. The photographer took pictures of our hiking trip who works for National Geographic.
5. The man changed my car's tires whom I cannot find him now.

Speak with your tutor

- "Check my answers to Exercises 13, 14 and 16 in the lesson material (combining sentences with subject and object relative pronouns and with whose)."
- "Exercise 22: I will find the adjective clauses and reduced clauses in the ten sentences from 'Life on Reservations' and the noun each one describes. Check me, and check my Exercise 21 (modals in the reading)."
- "Let's play Celebrity Guess Who (Exercise 25). I will describe a famous person in five sentences with adjective clauses, and you guess. Then you describe one for me."
- "I will tell you about a complicated situation from my past. Tell me what I should have done (Exercise 23). Then let's discuss what Dulce, Hawra and Claudia should do (Exercise 24)."

Read aloud

Restrictive clauses have no pauses. Non-restrictive clauses have a short pause at each comma (marked |).

- The girl who is sitting in the front is new.
- Mariam, | who is absent today, | speaks K'iche.
- The car that is in my driveway is my brother's.
- My car, | which needs to be washed, | rides smoothly.
- The woman whom you met at the party likes square dancing.

- The teacher whose class I am taking explains topics very well.

Writing task

Write a paragraph of 8-10 sentences about a famous person, or about a place at your school or in your city, without its name (like Exercise 25). End with "Who am I?" or "Where is this?".

- Use at least six adjective clauses with at least four different relative pronouns (who, whom, which, that, whose, where, when).
- Include at least one non-restrictive clause with commas and one reduced clause (a phrase).

Checklist:

- Is each clause next to the noun it describes?
- Did you use who for a subject and whom for an object?
- Are there commas around non-restrictive clauses, and no commas around restrictive clauses?
- Did you avoid an extra pronoun (not "the book that I read it")?
- Does the verb in each clause agree with its antecedent?
- Did you use which only with commas, as this lesson teaches?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- Relative Pronouns & Clauses-English Grammar Lesson: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=lLkARyk4CTI
- Commas or No Commas? Restrictive vs. Non-Restrictive Relative Clauses: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Syaip7v3Tao
- Relative Clauses with Whose: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=KEe3zAZeJ6s
- Reduced Relative Clauses: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rnNRxIia3sk

Answer key

Exercise 12. (book) 1. b (which has the highest incarceration rate in the world) 2. a (whose economy is collapsing) 3. a (that plays soft rock) 4. b (which often plays Stevie Nicks) 5. a (who smokes in her car; that prohibits smoking on its property is also restrictive)

Exercise 15. (book) 1. a 2. b 3. a 4. b 5. a 6. b 7. b 8. a 9. a 10. b

Exercise 17. (book, except item 6)

1. The place where I got married is outdoor. (In standard English, "is outdoors" or "is outside" is better than "is outdoor".)
2. The building where Irene lived collapsed.
3. The library where I spend most of my time closes at 3PM on Fridays.
4. The house where I grew up has changed a lot.
5. The day when you were born was the best day of my life.
6. I was sick Tuesday, when I had an exam. (The book's key says "I was sick Tuesday when I had an exam" with no comma; this is a mistake because Tuesday is a specific day that the reader already knows, so by this lesson's rule the clause is non-restrictive and needs a comma.)
7. February is the month when the temperatures are usually the coldest.

Exercise 18. (book) 1. c 2. c 3. c 4. a 5. b 6. b (Captain America, a Marvel superhero, first appeared in 1941.)

Exercise 19. (book) 1. b 2. a 3. c 4. b 5. d 6. c

Exercise 20.

1. The book that I bought through Amazon arrived late.
2. I went with my friend to the shopping mall that is the biggest in America. (or: My friend and I went to the shopping mall that is the biggest in America.)
3. The rooms where they go will be prepared. (or: The rooms that they go to will be prepared.)
4. The photographer who works for National Geographic took pictures of our hiking trip.
5. The man whom I cannot find now changed my car's tires.

My notes